

Ḥadīth

The term *ḥadīth* is used to denote a saying, act or tacit approval, validly or invalidly, ascribed to the Prophet (sws). The *muḥaddithūn* (experts in the science of *ḥadīth* criticism) also use the term *taqrīr* for tacit approvals. It means that, in the presence of the Prophet (sws), a believer did something, which the Prophet (sws) noticed but did not disapprove or condemn. Thus, the act done by a believer acquired tacit approval from the Prophet (sws). The *muḥaddithūn* use another term *khābar* for a *ḥadīth*. It is commonly acknowledged that *khābar* can be true or false. The scholars of the science of *ḥadīth* criticism hold that a *khābar* and, therefore, a *ḥadīth* can be a true report or a concoction. It is on the basis of this premise that the Muslim scholars hold that a *ḥadīth* offers a *ẓannī* (inconclusive/probably true) evidence. It is as though a *ḥadīth* may have many possibilities on the plane of reliability. It can be *ṣaḥīḥ*¹, *ḥasan*², *dha'if*³, *mawḍū'*⁴ etc. For obvious reasons, each of these kinds will be treated differently. They will be given different weight as the source text.

The Structure of Hadeeth حدیث کی ساخت

A Hadeeth consists of two main parts: (a) the *Sanad* and (b) the *Matn*

The Sanad: *Sanad* or *Isnad*, is the chain of narrators that leads to the text of the Hadeeth. The *Sanad* consists of all those who narrated the text, starting with the last narrator (who records the Hadeeth in his book) and ending with the Prophet.

The Matn: *Matn* The text of the Hadeeth or what the Prophet actually said or did is called the *Matn*.

Musaddad told us that Yahyaa informed him from Shu'bah, from Qataadah from Anas from the Prophet that he said: "None of you truly believes until he loves for his brother what he loves for himself." Collected by *al-Bukhari*

The Significance of the Sanad (the chain of narrators of Hadeeth): سند کی اہمیت

Even though the text (*Matn*) of a Hadeeth may seem to be logical and reasonable, it needs an authentic *Sanad* with reliable reporters to be acceptable.

But what did they mean by asking about Isnad?

The *Isnad* consists of the names of the reporters. Once the name of the reporter has come to light it was quiet possible to investigate whether he was trustworthy or not and whether he actually heard the person from whom he claimed the report. Criticism of this nature later came to be known as '*Ilm al-Jarh wal-Ta'dil* (Disparaging and authenticating).

Since a number of spurious (fabricated) Hadeeth found their way into the Hadeeth literature, the science of Hadeeth known as *Mustalah* مصطلح or *Ilm Usul al-Hadeeth* علم اصول الحدیث developed to distinguish between the authentic Hadeeth and the fabricated ones. The Scholars of Hadeeth have dealt with each Hadeeth as an independent case, subjecting both its individual *Isnad* and *Matn* (text) to extensive verification according to the principles laid down in this science. This is how separate collections of authentic Hadeeth and those of fabricated ones came into being.

Classification according to the beginning of the Sanad (سند کی ابتداء کے اعتبار سے تقسیم)

- 1. *Marfu* مرفوع (elevated) i.e. *Sanads* that go up to the Prophet
- 2. *Mauquf* موقوف (stopped) i.e. a *Sanad* that goes up to a successor (*Tabi'ee*) تابعی
- 3. *Maqtu* مقطوع (severed) i.e. a *Sanad* that goes up to *at-Tabaa at-Tabi'een* تابع تابعی

¹ A *ṣaḥīḥ ḥadīth* is transmitted through an unbroken chain of narrators all of whom are of sound character and memory. Such a *ḥadīth* should not clash with a more reliable report and must not suffer from any other hidden defect.

² A *ḥasan ḥadīth* is transmitted through an unbroken chain of narrators all of whom are of sound character but weak memory. This *ḥadīth* should not clash with a more reliable report and must not suffer from any other hidden defect.

³ A *dā'if ḥadīth* is that which cannot gain the status of *ḥasan* because it lacks one or more elements of a *ḥasan ḥadīth*. (For example, if the narrator is not of sound memory and sound character, or if there is a hidden fault in the narrative or if the chain of narrators is broken).

⁴ A *mawḍū' ḥadīth* is one that is fabricated and wrongly ascribed to the Holy Prophet (sws).

1- Marfu' مرفوع (elevated) It is a narration from the Prophet, that is when the narrator (a *Sahabee*, a *Taabiee* or other) says, “The Messenger of Allah said ...”

Example : The very first *Hadeeth* in *Saheeh al-Bukhari* is as follows *Al-Bukhari* -- - *Al-Humaidi* ‘*Abdullah bin al-Zubair* --- *Sufyan* --- *Yahya b. Sa'id al-Ansari* -- *Muhammed b. Ibrahim al-Taymi* --- *Alqamah b. Waqqas al-Laithi*, who said: I heard *Umer bin al-Khattab* saying, while on the pulpit, “I heard Allah’s Messenger saying, ‘The reward of deeds depends on the intention...’”

2-Mauquf موقوف (stopped) A narration from a Companion only, i.e. his own statement; e.g. *Al-Bukhari* reports in his *Saheeh in Kitaab al-Fara'id* (Book of the Laws of Inheritance), that *Abu Bakr*, *Ibn Abbas* and *Ibn al-Zubair* said, “The grandfather is (treated like) the father.”

It should be noted that certain expressions used by a Companion generally render a *Hadeeth* to be considered as being effectively *marfu'* although it is *mauquf* on the face of it, e.g. the following expressions

“We were commanded to ...” “We were forbidden from ...” “We used to do ...” “We used to say/do While the Messenger of Allah was amongst us.” “We did not used to mind such and such ...” “It is from the *Sunnah* to ...” It was revealed in the following circumstances ...”, speaking about a verse of the *Qur'an*.

3- Maqtu' مقطوع (Severed) A narration from a Successor, e.g. *Imam Muslim* reports in the introduction to his *Sahih* that *Ibn Sirin* (d.110) said, “This knowledge (i.e. *Hadith*) is the Religion, so be careful from whom you take your religion.”

Classification according to the number of reporters involved in each stage of *isnad* راديوں کی تعداد کے اعتبار سے تقسیم

1-Mutawatir (consecutive) متواتر A *Mutawatir Hadeeth* is one which is reported by such a large number of people that they cannot be expected to agree upon a lie, all of them together. *Al-Ghazali* (d.505) stipulates that a *Mutawatir* narration be known by a sizeable number of its reporters equally in the beginning, in the middle and in the end. The important condition is that the possibility of coincidence or “organized falsehood” be obviously negligible.

2- Ahad (isolated) آحاد A *Hadeeth Ahad* or a *Khabr-e-Wahid* is one which is narrated by people whose number does not reach that of the *Mutawatir* case.

1- Gharib (strange) غریب when only a single reporter is found relating it at some stage of the *Sanad*.

2- Aziz (rare) عزیز only two reporters

3-Mashhur (famous) مشہور reported by more than two reporters

Authoritativeness of *Akhbār-i Āḥād*

Akhbār-i Āḥād اخبار آحاد

An individual-to-individual report (*khavar-i wāḥid*) is a report transmitted by one or more narrators in each or any of the layers of transmitters while short of becoming a *mutawātir* (concurrent) report. This means that *akhbār-i āḥād* include the traditions narrated by a single narrator or more than one in any or all of the layers in its *isnād*. They, however, always remain short of the number that renders a narrative *mutawātir*.

- **Mālikī View**

Imām Mālik and his followers do not attach any importance to *akhbār-i āḥād* against the consensual practice of the people of *Madīnah*. They consider the practice of the people of *Madīnah* as the *Sunnah* of the Prophet (sws) because, according to them, *Madīnah* was the city of the Prophet (sws) and his Companions (*rtā*). A practice adopted by the habitants of *Madīnah* with consensus becomes the *Sunnah* and, as such, it has to be preferred over *akhbār-i āḥād*.

- **Hanaḥī View**

They do not attach much importance to *akhbār-i āḥād* in matters concerning *‘umūm-i balwā* (عموم) (general and every day human issues).

Shāfi‘ī View

Imām Shāfi‘ī very emphatically states that individual narratives are authoritative without exception. He stresses that even a narrative transmitted by a single narrator in each layer of a chain of transmission (*gharīb*) provides definitive authority.

The Principle View:

The Almighty commands us to consider personality of reporters as well as nature, indicators and characteristics of the news while deciding on its truth value. If the reporter is not impious (*fāsiq*) then we may not critically analyze the news and the reporter even if he gives important news. If, a *fāsiq* reporter communicates something concerning ordinary matters of daily life we need not critically analyze the report. However, if a *fāsiq* reporter narrates something important then we have to analyze his report and his character. We shall investigate his character and ability; we shall study the nature of the news and its relevant characteristics and indicators. If all these elements favour and support the report then we may accept it otherwise not.

Conclusion

Akhbār-i āḥād are no doubt a major source of transmission of the prophetic knowledge. However, it would not be right to hold that *akhbār-i āḥād* alone can sufficiently establish the reliability of the reported knowledge. *Akhbār-i āḥād* are not rejected as unacceptable merely because they are *akhbār-i āḥād*. Rather, they are relied on while being careful regarding different aspects of weakness in them. The scholars, however, must look for ways of eliminating the possibility of error in such reports using all available sources and resources of knowledge. Indicators, analogy, supporting evidence, oaths, and all other possible ways of removing doubts and uncertainty involved in such historical knowledge shall be employed. However, *akhbār-i āḥād* shall definitely be rejected if they contradict foundational religious knowledge in Islam. This principle is derived from the Qur’ān and the *mutawātir Sunnah*.

Hadith Saheeh حديث صحيح

1. *Ittisaal as-Sanad* اتصال السند (Continuity of the chain of transmitters) Meeting + known narrator
2. *‘Adaalah* عدالت (integrity)
3. *Dabt* ضبط (accuracy)
 - (a) *Dabt as-Sadr* ضبط الصدر (Soundness of memory)
 - (b) *Dabt al-Kitaabah* ضبط الكتابات (Written accuracy)
4. *Ghayr Shaathth* غير شاذ (conformity)
5. *Laa ‘Illah* لا علة (absence of hidden defect)

- **Ruling of Hadeeth Saheeh**

Such a *hadeeth* can be used to establish points of Islamic law and, if it isn’t abrogated, it must be accepted and applied. The ruling of a *hadeeth saheeh* can only be superseded by that of another *hadeeth saheeh* stronger than it.

Hadith Hasan حديث حسن

A hadith is considered *hasan* if it fulfills all the requirements of *Sihhah* except *Dabt* (accuracy).

- **Ruling on the *Hadeeth Hasan***

The *hadeeth hasan* is valid for establishing Islamic rulings that should not be rejected unless abrogated or superseded by a *hadeeth saheeh*.

Hadith Da'eef حديث ضعيف

A hadith, in which any one or more of the five conditions of *Sihhah* صحاح have not been met.

- **Ruling on *Da'eef* Narrations**

The majority permitted its application for meritorious deeds not pertaining to theology or legal rulings (*halaal* and *haraam*).